

HOUZZ PRO EBOOK

Managing Difficult *Conversations*



Your go-to ebook for turning around a bad review, resolving client disputes and saying no without burning bridges in the design and remodeling industries.

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INTRODUCTION

Do tough conversations make you want to head for the nearest cave? Does getting negative feedback send your head into a tailspin? You're not alone.

Even seasoned pros can shy away from conflict, whether in the form of a less-than-stellar review or the need to tell a client no. But putting off hard discussions can harm your business. "When we avoid difficult conversations, we trade short-term discomfort for long-term dysfunction," says consultant and speaker Peter Bromberg. In this guide we'll share not just how to make those discussions a little less uncomfortable but also how to use them to your advantage — to make your business stronger, your communications more effective and your day-to-day life more manageable.



CHAPTER ONE

01

Received a Bad Review? Here's How to Turn It Around — Part 1

Negative feedback is a golden opportunity. Learn how to make the most of it

Received a Bad Review? Here's How to Turn It Around — Part 1

You can't please all of the people all of the time. As an industry professional with many clients, you're bound to receive at least one bad review. Unfortunately, that one bad review is unlikely to go unnoticed these days. In this two-part series, we share how to put a positive spin on negative reviews. Here we'll cover adopting the right mindset and taking the first steps.



A bad review also creates an opportunity to showcase your professionalism, customer relationship management, work ethic and ability to turn things around.

First, why should you care about a lone bad review at all? The answer: 84% of people trust reviews as much as personal recommendations, so even a single negative comment can affect your reputation. But don't despair. A bad review also creates an opportunity to showcase your professionalism, customer relationship management, work ethic and ability to turn things around. So it actually can work in your favor.

Case in point: Among architect Anders Lasater's numerous five-star reviews is a lone three-star rating. While disappointed, he acknowledged the critique and apologized for the issue, and ended up turning a negative into a positive. "I had many clients tell me that the one review that was most telling was my bad review, because they really liked my response. My response is what made them realize I'm a professional and I'd be a good person to work with," he says. "What I learned was that a bad review is maybe not a bad thing at all. Maybe it's a good thing."

Lasater turned a potential pitfall into an advantage, and this guide will show you how you can too.

1. Take a time-out, then acknowledge the issue.

Don't reply to a review if you're feeling angry; wait until you've cooled down. While you're waiting, think honestly about the issue the client brought up. There may be a learning and growth opportunity here. Even if not, you want to respond courteously and professionally. Designer John Hare of Core Design in Texas offers this: "I've seen a business owner respond badly to a negative review on Google, and it not only sets up a toxic atmosphere when mishandled, it also doesn't do any good for you and your business."

2. Take the high road.

When you're in the right frame of mind, start formulating your response with empathy. Especially if the reviewer's comment is rude or even ridiculous, a courteous and thoughtful response will show your integrity and professionalism. Acknowledge the issue and ease any tension with a phrase like "I understand your frustration."

As Jeannine Burnett, owner of Access + Design Build in Minneapolis, puts it, this is an opportunity to "grow from the experience and move on." Burnett recognizes that interior design is very subjective by nature. "You won't always be everyone's favorite," she says. Remind yourself that this is your chance to learn and showcase your diplomacy to the online community.

3. Offer a reminder.

Also remember that some people don't have a clear idea of what they want until it's in front of them. "It's why they hired you," Burnett says. You can gently remind an upset client why certain choices were made, while showing that you understand where he or she is coming from too.

Designer Natasha Burton of NB Interiors UK, who specializes in curating meaningful and personalized interiors in her projects around the Suffolk, Essex and London areas in UK, has seen firsthand the benefits of responding to reviews. "I've had so many clients coming to me because of the amount of reviews I've received, but also because of my response," she says.

4. Apologize quickly, and mean it.

Taking responsibility and being sincere will go a long way here. If your tone is off or your words feel forced or overused, your apology will fall flat. Aim to offer a genuine and direct apology. Avoid padding your apology with adjectives such as "genuinely," "truly," and "honestly." Something like "I'm sorry this was your experience" should work. If you really feel apologetic, it will come across as sincere.

Nate Fischer of Nate Fischer Interiors in Laguna Niguel, California, has avoided bad reviews by sticking to the belief that the customer is always right. "If your client is not happy, they are not happy, whether it's your responsibility or not," he says. "I always offer more time and energy when needed to ensure that a client is happy with their project. It's not easy but has proven to be the best solution for me."



CHAPTER TWO

02

Received a Bad Review? Here's How to Turn It Around — Part 2

Come away stronger, wiser and in a better frame of mind using these ideas

Received a Bad Review? Here's How to Turn It Around

— Part 2

Chafing at a bad review of your services? Our two-part series can help. Part 1 covered adopting the right mindset and taking the first steps. Here we'll discuss how to share your side diplomatically while working to resolve the issue.

1. Provide your side of the story, being mindful of tone.

Responding to a negative review lets you offer your take and reasons, following the acknowledgement and apology. It can be tricky, since you don't want to come across as defensive or accusatory. Don't make excuses; rather, share your reasons or explanation politely and tactfully. For example, if a client says you didn't respond to their or messages in a timely manner, you could say something like, "This happened during a time when I took on a larger number of clients than usual, which is something I'm making sure not to do going forward." Show that you've taken responsibility and worked to change your behavior. This will reassure prospective clients that the same issue won't happen with them.

Remodeling contractor Hennie Schoeman of Schoeman Construction in Tampa, Florida, finds it worthwhile to make his company's side of the story available for online readers — including potential clients. "I have always gone back to our emails and simply copied the facts I promised," he says. Being honest about what was discussed, but in a diplomatic way, shows not just professionalism but thoughtfulness.

When custom home builder Bryan Payne of Many Mansions in Arizona can tell a client isn't happy or well-informed before or during a project, he'll reach out right away. "I'll explain exactly again how I do things and reiterate my value," he says. Payne adds that the person usually comes around to understanding his fees and processes if there had been any misunderstanding before.

2. Choose your words — and punctuation — carefully.

How you say things is often more important than what you say. In the digital landscape, without aural input and body language, punctuation and word choice become extra important. You can use exclamation

points to show your apology is heartfelt, but only if they feel sincere. And avoid defensive phrases such as, “I’m sorry my service didn’t exceed your expectations” or, “I’m sorry, but I was only doing my job.”

✦ | **How you say things is often more important than what you say.**

Maintaining diplomacy in general with clients, as well as staying true to your word, will of course help prevent bad reviews from occurring in the first place. Schoeman advises, “Do what you say you will do, show up when you say you will, give the client realistic expectations and don’t make promises you cannot keep.”

3. Try to fix the issue, and communicate effectively.

Actions speak louder than words. At the end of your reply, ask what can be done to rectify the situation. Because Houzz allows clients to change their reviews at any time, fixing a problem can turn a bad review around. It also can have a profoundly positive effect on your reputation and success. Feel free to invite the reviewer to continue the conversation offline, so you can come up with a solution together without an online audience.

Dan Nelson, principal of Design Northwest Architects in Stanwood, Washington, says that when he has a project that presents issues, he’s very proactive in communicating the reasons to the client. “I’ll then explain that I will personally address the issue and fix it,” he says. “It would be the same process if I ever had to receive a negative comment online.”

Once an issue has been resolved, don’t be afraid to ask the client, offline, to reword the review. Christina Bailey of Lasley Brahaney Architecture + Construction in Princeton, New Jersey, uses this tactic. “If we do encounter a bad review,” she says, “we would reach out to the homeowners to iron things out, and when the issues are resolved, we would request a new or revised review.”

4. Avoid future issues too.

Being proactive about soliciting feedback from clients can minimize the risk of receiving a negative review in the future. Jennifer Coates, lead designer at the award-winning nationwide architectural and interior design studio JL Coates Design, sends her clients a survey at the end of each project phase. “Since there are many different parts to the project, we want to get feedback for each phase of the job,” she says. Coates values her clients’ feedback and uses it to prepare better and prevent any issues going forward — keeping clients happy and the company’s sterling reputation intact.

Contractor and designer Taghi Shaw of Waze Development in

Cambridge, Massachusetts, knows the importance of maintaining a good name in this industry. "Your reputation is everything," Shaw says. To ensure he's always managing his clients' expectations, Taghi sends them pictures of his construction progress. "I always communicate on text with my clients," he says. "I'll send them updates as we're going along just to make sure, and ask, 'Are you happy with this? Is there anything we need to change?' I think that kind of communication is important so that your clients don't get to the finish line and they look at it and say, 'That's not what I thought it would turn out to be.'" This strategy helps keep Shaw in good standing with both current and future clients.



Being proactive about soliciting feedback from clients can minimize the risk of receiving a negative review in the future.

Designer Ginger Curtis of Urbanology Designs in North Richland Hills, Texas, sums up the ideal approach to addressing negative reviews: "When dealing with a bad review, it's important to validate the concerns of the client. Contact them and let them know it is of utmost importance to you that they feel understood and that you want to address their concerns in a manner that fully satisfies them and is fair for all involved," she advises. "Always remember: You don't have to be right, you just have to get it right! Getting it right means letting go of your pride and addressing client concerns or a bad review with the goal of them being totally satisfied and removing the review."





CHAPTER THREE

03

5 Communication Strategies to Successfully Resolve Client Disputes

Whether you're a designer, home renovation specialist or contractor, learn how to handle disagreements with ease

5 Communication Strategies to Successfully Resolve Client Disputes

Conflict is part and parcel of any client relationship, especially in the complex world of home renovation, design and construction. In an ideal world, every project would run on time, everyone would see eye to eye and clients would be understanding and patient. However, from disagreements and missed deadlines to money problems and delayed orders, numerous issues might arise between you and your clients.

Of course, the best way to manage conflict is to keep it from happening in the first place. Seasoned pros know that communication is key. Are you and your client on the same page about pricing, scheduling and materials, so you don't end up disagreeing over how something looks or how much something costs? Do your clients understand your work process so they know what to expect? And finally, do you know how to be upfront about your workload and backlog so that a conflict doesn't arise about how long a project is taking to complete?

Even if you answered yes to all the questions above, and you communicate effectively and often, conflict can still occur. Managing a dispute the right way will help you turn a negative into a positive, and will demonstrate your leadership skills, help foster trust and ultimately position you as a business that cares. Handling conflict the wrong way can lose you customers, damage your business reputation and affect your bottom line.

There is an art to handling conflict, and it's important for all business owners to understand which communication strategies are effective.



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Here are five actions to take.

1. Listen actively.

You may be hearing what your client has to say, but are you actually listening? Active listening is listening to understand, not listening to respond. It involves paying close attention and demonstrating to the speaker that you're engaged. You can show this by nodding as the person speaks, asking nonjudgmental questions, reflecting on what is said and

summarizing the conversation. It's also important not to interrupt and to let the client speak. Active listening makes the speaker feel valued and heard, which is extremely important in maintaining positive client relationships. It will also make it easier to come to a resolution, as you will more clearly understand exactly what the client needs from you.

2. Focus on facts, not emotion.

It's important to be objective during conflict resolution. Base the conversation on the facts at hand — the who, what, where, when, why and how — rather than on how either of you is feeling. It's easy to get defensive, frustrated or angry when trying to resolve an issue, but this will only worsen the situation. Remain calm and lead with reason. If



Remain calm and lead with reason.

you're able to control your emotions, you'll be able to communicate more effectively without making the other person feel overwhelmed or threatened.

If the conversation does require you to talk about emotions, use phrases like "I feel" or "When you did X, it caused me to feel X." This will help keep clients from feeling like you're putting the blame on them, and will keep them open to listening and reaching a solution.

3. Be mindful of body language.

Did you know that only 7% of a message is conveyed through words, while the remaining 93% is conveyed by body language and tone of voice? In other words, what you're saying is less important than how you're saying it.

Things like gestures, posture, eye contact, facial expressions and tone of voice all affect the way someone receives what you're saying. Therefore, trying to resolve a conflict in person or by video call will be more fruitful than doing so over text or email, as you'll be able to demonstrate your points more clearly and avoid being misinterpreted.

One of the main sources of miscommunication occurs when body language doesn't match words. For example, if you struggle to maintain eye contact with your client while trying to resolve the conflict, you may be unintentionally conveying the message that you don't want to be having the conversation, even if your words say otherwise. This will make clients feel as though their problems aren't worth your time, and it can detract from any progress you're making.

4. Show empathy.

It's important for clients to feel you care about their issue. They want to feel that their concerns are important and that you're willing to put in the work to resolve them. You can show you care by listening carefully and relaying back to them your understanding of the problem. Try to put yourself in their shoes and consider their perspective rather than trying to defend yourself. Let them know you hear them, that you're sorry and that you're going to do everything in your power to reach a solution.

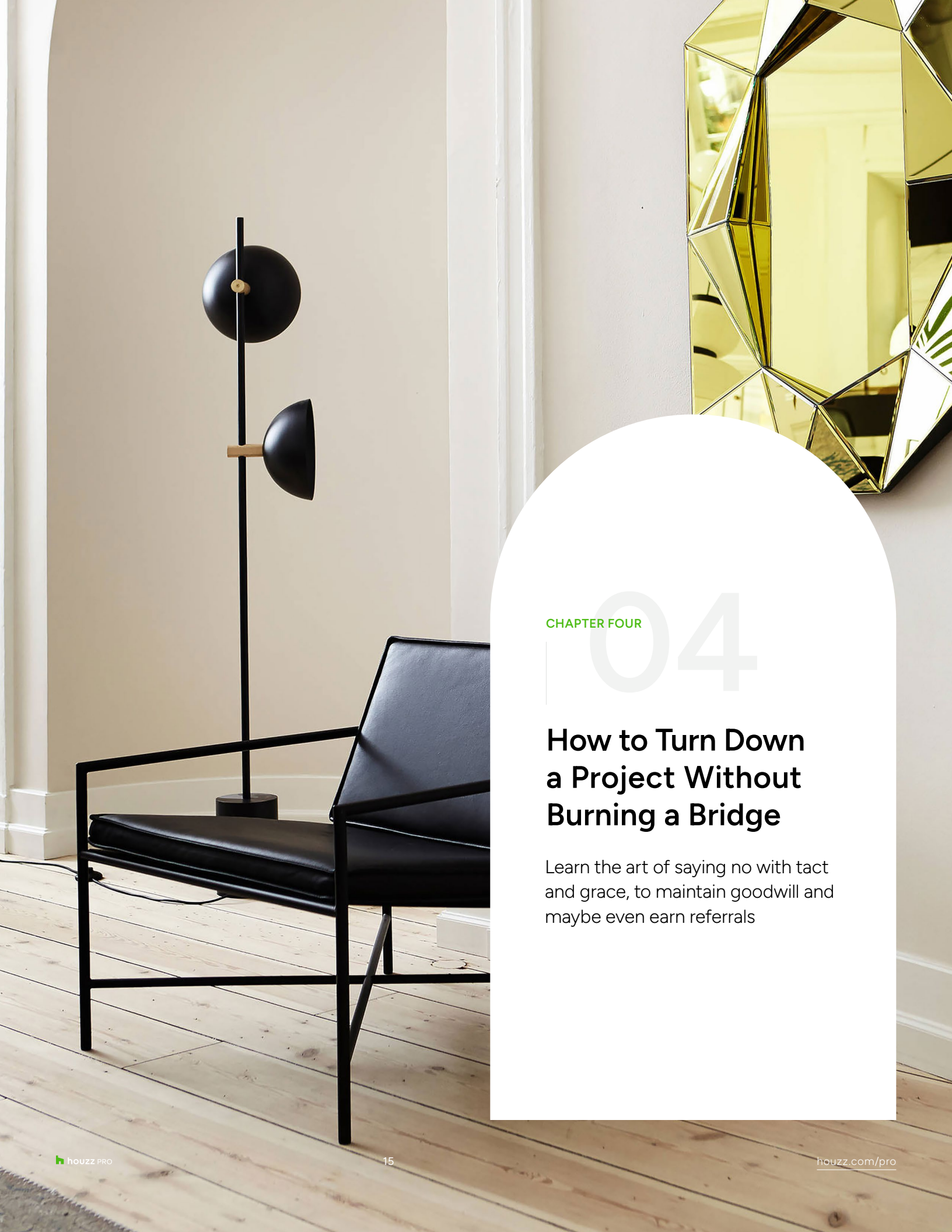
5. Choose your words carefully.

Your choice of words can drastically affect the way the listener perceives what you're saying. Some words have negative connotations and convey an unintentional message. Certain words can also trigger a negative reaction or cause the client to become defensive. A good example of how to avoid this is using "and" instead of "but." The word "but" usually excludes, denies or discounts the previous sentence. For instance, let's say you want to convey a problem. The sentence "You want us to have this done by the end of the week, and our team is already working on another deadline" sounds more positive than "You want us to have this done by the end of the week, but our team is already working on another deadline." When you use the first phrase, the client is invited to consider the problem you're facing rather than hear it as an argument or defense.



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Honing these key communication strategies is vital to maintaining positive client relationships, which are the backbone of any business. While no one wants to invite conflict into their relationships, business owners shouldn't fear it, as it can actually have a positive result if handled correctly. So don't shy away from your next client dispute. Instead, face it head-on and see it as an opportunity to demonstrate your expertise and empathy.



CHAPTER FOUR

04

How to Turn Down a Project Without Burning a Bridge

Learn the art of saying no with tact and grace, to maintain goodwill and maybe even earn referrals

How to Turn Down a Project Without Burning a Bridge

It's perfectly OK to turn down work for whatever reason you see fit, be it a disparity between your style and the client's, a realization that the scope of the project will stretch you too thin, or a gut feeling that a homeowner will be high-maintenance and impossible to please.

Of course, you always want to be professional and polite in your communications with clients, and should leave out any negative personal feelings about the project or the person behind it. Thank the person for the opportunity and wish him or her success.

Beyond that, you can decide how generic or personal, cursory or detailed to be depending on how much time you've spent together and other factors — such as if you've worked with the person in the past, or it's a referral from one of your top clients.

Consider the following four strategies, choose the one that best fits the individual situation, then free yourself up for meeting new clients whom you'll mesh with more easily.

1. Blame your bandwidth.

It may be the most generic refusal, but that doesn't mean it's not legit: "I'm sorry, but we don't currently have the bandwidth to take on additional clients."

If you feel compelled to elaborate, you can explain that you've just finalized some new projects. Or say that you're contractually committed to other work that prevents you from accepting theirs.

2. Convey "It's not you, it's me."

The classic breakup line can be useful with clients too. Avoid placing any blame on the client by saying you regret that the project is out

of your area of expertise.

3. Give a referral.

Just because certain clients aren't right for you doesn't mean they won't be a fit for someone else. So think of other designers in your network you could refer them to: an established interior designer with a strong, no-nonsense personality could be the right fit for a difficult homeowner. A hungry-for-work newbie might be willing to take on a project with a tiny budget.

Take a little time to do some design world matchmaking, and you might find you get referred by others too.

4. Keep it short, sweet...and honest.

In some cases, there's no need to over explain. Simply let the person know that you appreciate the opportunity, but you don't think you're the best match for the project based on budget, timeline or aesthetic. Done.





CHAPTER FIVE

05

3 Must-Know Tips for Those Critical Client Conversations

Smooth out the renovation process while building trust — and your reputation — by following this essential advice

3 Must-Know Tips for Those Critical Client Conversations

No matter how well you plan, you can't control every step on the path to completing a design or construction project. Unforeseen weather, shipping delays and employee illnesses are just a few of the inevitable bumps. And how you handle these makes all the difference — not just for your professional reputation and client satisfaction, but for general goodwill and your own peace of mind. Here we'll share best practices for both setting the stage for success and navigating critical conversations with grace.

1. Actively educate clients.

Use your online presence to lay the groundwork that can help set expectations and avoid miscommunications. Share on your Houzz profile or website essential information about your firm's core principles, your design or building philosophies and style, and how you approach and handle the design or building process. On social media, post photos, positive reviews and any other material that supports these elements. That way, prospective clients can get a good sense of whether you're the right fit before they even pick up the phone.

Consider being proactive about reviews too, not just in soliciting them but in asking clients to address specific points in their write-ups. You might ask them to elaborate on how you solved a particular design problem or how they appreciated being kept informed every step of the way, for instance.

When you first meet clients in person, or via video or phone chat, explain the importance of having a detailed contract to ensure that everyone is on the same page. And be honest about any potential issues that may crop up once the project begins. "I'm honest with clients in the sense that before they sign on, they are aware that nothing is guaranteed in terms of timelines, products and materials," says Charli Junker of Canadian design firm Your Space Our Design. "I also give examples of other project delays and standard delays versus COVID delays. The client is definitely

aware of this before the project starts.”

2. Get crystal clear on the budget and design.

Clients may tend to underestimate how much products and services cost these days, especially if they’ve never renovated or built anything before, or if it’s been a while. So it’s essential to discuss the budget in detail with clients and put everything in writing. But you can reduce the chances of budget issues even before then by specifying on your Houzz profile and website the typical budget range of your projects.

Once you’ve confirmed that the budget will work for you both, follow up regarding the specific design, an action plan and a timeline, including a payment schedule. And don’t forget to include what would happen if the scope of work changes. Doing this all by email will create a written record you can both refer to later on. It “helps them, and they get excited again for that new date,” says landscape designer Elizabeth Przygoda-Montgomery of [Boxhill](#) in Tucson, Arizona. “It helps for ease of reference as well,” she adds. “This is usually discussed in multiple ways, but I prefer written documentation in email so that there is no confusion and an easy place to reference.”

Many design and building pros rely on [Houzz Pro](#) to handle all project-related messaging, as it stores all communications, documents and client approvals in one place—no sifting through various messaging accounts and types. You can also share photos and files, estimates and 3D floor plans with clients, which they can approve online.

3. Run the renovation smoothly.

You’ve already laid the groundwork for minimal misunderstandings with clear communication, and that effort doesn’t end when you begin the project. Start by setting clear boundaries for your clients regarding the best times and ways to communicate with you. If you never respond on weekends and prefer emails over texts, for example, be open about it to avoid frustration for both of you.

Don’t shy away from asking direct questions and sharing information about potential issues. For instance, if a product shipment is delayed, share that info instead of trying to cover it up. That way you and the client can find a solution that works for both of you.

“Honesty is the best policy,” Junker says. “I find that screenshotting emails or forwarding emails directly from suppliers [about delayed shipments] is best. This shows good faith on my part and builds a sense of trust.”

And for any conversation when something doesn’t go as planned, try to have it face to face or at least over the phone instead of emailing or

texting. Body language and tone convey subtleties that might be missed in written communication; you can create more goodwill when the client can see you, and in turn you can also read your client better and respond appropriately in real time.

"I don't ever send emails when I'm disappointing someone," Przygoda-Montgomery says. "We make the hard call. We explain what happened. Then, we empathize."

If you're dreading that conversation, consider writing out a script so you feel more prepared. But however you approach it, it's important to be empathetic and attentive, and to use a gentle but firm and confident tone. Validate the client's feelings instead of trying to defend your actions, choices, suppliers or employees. Ask follow-up questions to emphasize that you're paying attention and trying to come up with a solution, and share your plan if you have one. Doing so will strengthen the relationship



"I tell my clients, 'There are three key components to any project: time, budget and quality. You can pick two of the three, but I can't give you all three.' Everyone inevitably picks budget and quality. This has been a really effective way to set timeline expectations at the beginning of our projects."

Wiley Gilliam, Modern Craft Construction

with your client, helping you get a positive result from a negative event.

Bonus tip: Schedule the conversation in advance so you're both in the right frame of mind, rather than catching the client off guard.

Get the all-in-one tool that
helps you grow and manage
your business.

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